



HIGHER HEALTH

2025

POLICY ON E-LEARNING AND STUDENT-CENTRED E-LEARNING SUPPORT



Policy on e-learning and student-centred e-learning support

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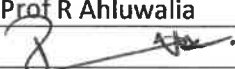
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Glossary

“Access” means entry to an occupational qualification, part-qualification or skills programme, or entry to a final external summative assessment

“Barriers” mean policies, attitudes, practices, inaccessibility of the virtual environment, which adversely affect students with disabilities’ prospects of entry and/or participation in the learning experience

“Certification” means formal recognition of a qualification or part-qualification or accredited skills programme awarded to a successful learner

“Curriculum” means a statement of the training structure and expected methods of learning and teaching that underpin a qualification or part-qualification or skills programme to facilitate a more general understanding of its implementation in an education system

“Disability” means a social construct resulting from the interaction between a person’s impairment and associated barriers

“e-learning” means a mode of teaching and learning that makes use of technology-mediated features.

“Feedback” means specific reporting from the teacher to the learner or between learners, on how they have performed in an assessment activity, regardless of the level of formality of the assessment activity. Feedback specifies what was done well, and why, and offers clear guidance regarding what is missing or still needs development in learners’ texts, performances, or demonstrations, to enhance learning.

“Impairment” means a physical, sensory, mental, emotional, or cognitive condition resulting from an injury, illness, trauma, and/or congenital factors which are permanent, long term or recurring and which cause or is likely to cause a loss or difference of physiological or psychological functioning. The impairment can be visible or invisible. The impairment substantively affects the way the student accesses the learning experience and may require reasonable accommodation measures to be put in place.

“Learner” is an inclusive term referring to anyone learning, including pupils, students, apprentices, interns, learners in learnerships, people doing training, and people learning non-formally and informally as well as people enrolled for qualifications or part-qualifications, and people learning in contact, distance, and self-study contexts at all levels in the system.

“Learning” means the acquisition of knowledge, understanding, values, skills, competence, and/or experience

“Learning outcomes” mean the contextually demonstrated end-products of specific learning processes, which include knowledge, skills, and values.

“Level” means one of the series of levels of learning achievement arranged in ascending order from one to 10 according to which the NQF is organised and to which qualification types are linked

“National Qualifications Framework (NQF)” is a comprehensive system approved by the Minister of Higher Education and Training for the classification, registration, publication, and articulation of quality assured national qualifications.

“Persons with disabilities” means those who have long-term impairments and/or chronic conditions which in interaction with various barriers may hinder their full and effective participation in society on an equitable basis with others

“Quality” means meeting the requirements of nationally agreed outcomes and performance/assessment criteria, thus facilitating both provision and monitoring.

“Quality Assurance” means the processes of ensuring that specified standards or requirements for teaching, learning, education administration, assessment, and the recording of achievements have been met. The OQSF further defines it as systems and procedures to ensure that occupational qualifications meet industry standards and requirements

“Reasonable accommodation” means any modification or adjustment to the environment which will enable a student with a disability to have access to, take part in, or advance in academia. These measures ensure that persons with disabilities enjoy equitable opportunities and are equitably represented in the Higher Health student community

“Skills Programme” means a QCTO-accredited learning programme that is occupationally based and which, when completed, may constitute credits towards a qualification registered on the NQF.

1. Background

Higher Health is a non-profit organisation focused on the health and wellness of the youth in the post-school education and training (PSET) sector, and those not in education and training (NEET). Higher Health's model of delivering health and wellness services is to empower PSET learners to take charge of their health and wellness, through education and knowledge. Higher Health's programmes are intense and were delivered in-person. It soon became clear that more learners could be reached if the programmes were offered online, via e-learning. Learners also wanted recognition for attending the sessions. Higher Health therefore developed its e-learning Civic and Health Peer Education Programme, 30 credits; and Civic and Soft Skills Programme, 60 credits, which the QCTO accredited at NQF Level 5. Going forward, Higher Health will also offer a 15-credit Skills for Life programme, designed to fit into the university orientation programme.

Higher Health has made the distinction between a learning programme being offered online, and an e-learning programme. The difference between the two lies in the curriculum design. Higher Health's skills programmes are designed to be offered on an e-learning platform, with the entire process from learner registration to auto-graded assessments and final certification taking place through the e-learning platform. The main reason for Higher Health's move to e-learning, is to be able to enrol large numbers (hundreds of thousands) of learners onto its programme.

Higher Health has worked with its partners, the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO), and the Health and Welfare SETA (HWSETA) to develop and get approval for its end-to-end digital programme methodology.

However, the reality in South Africa is that learners from disadvantaged backgrounds do not necessarily have access to smart devices or data. These students often have limited digital literacy. Higher Health therefore makes provision for a hybrid and adaptive model of teaching and learning. This model allows Higher Health to arrange for students to attend weekend, or after-hour camps hosted in the computer labs of their colleges. Higher Health provides meals, smart devices, and data to enable learning. A facilitator is onsite to help with induction that includes a short course on digital literacy, to enable the student to proceed with the online programme.

PSET institutions acknowledge the role of Higher Health's programmes as co-curricula to the institutions' qualifications. While qualifications prepare the youth for the workplace by providing them with technical skills, Higher Health's programmes build resilience, empower students to

recognise, and seek help for social, health and wellness issues, and prepare students for the workplace by teaching them the critical soft skills demanded by the workplace. Higher Health enrolls students onto its programmes in collaboration with the universities, TVET and CET Colleges where they are currently enrolled. Institutions also collaborate with Higher Health when setting up physical camps at these institutions' computer labs, and track student progress on Higher Health's skills programmes.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to describe Higher Health's approach to e-learning for its online skills programmes; and its learner support that includes learners living with disabilities, to ensure that all learners have equal opportunities to succeed.

- a. Higher Health's approach is to embrace creative and innovative teaching and learning methods that include the "Each one, teach ten" pedagogy.

3. Legislative and Regulatory Framework

This policy must be read in conjunction with:

- I. QCTO OQSF Policy (2021);
- II. General Principles and Minimum Requirements on E-Assessment of Qualifications and Part Qualifications on the Occupational Qualifications Sub-Framework (OQSF);
- III. Strategic policy framework on disability for the post-school education and training system (2016), Department of Higher Education and Training;
- IV. Promotion of Equality and Prevention of Unfair Discrimination Act, No. 4 of 2000;
- V. UN Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities;
- VI. Web Accessibility Initiative (WAI) Guidelines & Techniques, World Wide Web Consortium (W3C); and
- VII. Higher Health's Policies:
 - i. Policy on Programme development;
 - ii. Policy on Admissions;
 - iii. Policy on Language;
 - iv. Policy on Assessment;
 - v. Policy on Quality Assurance;
 - vi. Policy on Certification; and
 - vii. IT Policy

4. Scope and Application

This policy applies to all Higher Health employees involved in the Higher Health Academy, from programme development to student enrolment and completion; and all learners enrolled on Higher Health's skills programmes that are accredited as such by the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO).

5. Principles

Higher Health has adopted the following best practices:

- a. Higher Health created a learner-centred environment that puts learners at the centre of all communication about the programme expectations, learner support services, technical assistance, focus groups to monitor learners' experiences of the e-learning platform, and learner progress. A learner-centred approach requires that learners are seen as the main foci of the educational process, and they are supported to take progressive responsibility for their learning. The pedagogy employed should:
 - i. Enable successful learning through rich environments for active learning;
 - ii. Establish links between learners' current meanings and contexts and knowledges and new knowledge to be constructed; and
 - iii. Encourage independent, creativity, and critical thinking.
- b. Higher Health has an active and engaging learning environment comprising targeted activities designed to stimulate interest; to allow for learning while doing; encourage peer interactions and learning through collaborations and online discussions; and to practise soft skills.
- c. Higher Health responds promptly to learner questions through its online platform, a dedicated email address for course-related questions, and online facilitators who customise communication to specific individuals or cohorts.
- d. Higher Health commits to building effective liaison systems to facilitate the sharing of information with PSET institutions when learning disabilities or the need for accommodations emerges. This will be done with student consent in the interests of ensuring a globally enhanced learning journey.
- e. Higher Health has an e-learning system that has:
 - i. Unique Usernames and Passwords
 - ii. The means to proctor learners using passwords for summative assessments
 - iii. A secure and authenticated platform
 - iv. Audio and video files and content available in multiple languages (still in development)
 - v. Quizzes and activities for self-assessments

- vi. Auto-graded formative and summative assessments (Refer to Higher Health's Assessment Policy)
- vii. Chatrooms and discussion forums for peer learning and sharing, to encourage cooperation, collaboration, and solidarity
- viii. Additional Resources for further information on a topic
- ix. Document upload function for logbooks and evidence of completed activities such as uploading voice-notes, videos, and graphics
- x. Automated certification of participation on completion of modules, and certificate of completion after successful completion of the final FISA assessment (Refer to Higher Health's Certification Policy)
- xi. Cloud-based backups, and regular physical backups (Refer to Higher Health's IT Policy)
- xii. Security features are in place to prevent hacking and security breaches
- xiii. 24-hour access from any smart device
- xiv. Flexibility to accommodate rapidly changing technologies
- xv. The support of a global technology partner with decades of experience, that guarantees that the e-learning platform is always available, and keeps up with technological developments; and
- xvi. The means to accommodate learners who are sight and hearing impaired. The online platform, Blackboard, includes Blackboard ALLY, which allows for content to be converted to different formats, including Braille for visually impaired students. Furthermore, all videos have downloadable transcriptions, and all long pieces of text have voice-overs.

Higher Health's e-learning offerings embody the following principles:

- f. The curriculum design is guided by principles related to learning outcomes, as described in the "Level Descriptors for the South African NQF" (SAQA, 2012), that describe what learners should know and be able to do (applied competence) once they have completed the programme. These outcomes are pegged at a particular level of learning and measured using credit values, which show the amount of learning time (notional hours) required to achieve them. The use of learning outcomes, NQF levels and credits as a principle in curriculum design is therefore key to the functioning of the NQF. (Refer to Higher Health's Policy of Programme Development).
- g. All content is available on the e-learning platform that may be downloaded onto a smart device and read offline.

- h. E-Learning is encouraged as it allows learners to access programmes that they might not otherwise have access to.
- i. Learners can learn at their own pace within the prescribed period of a year.
- j. Learners have the flexibility to begin with any of the modules, provided that they complete a module before moving on to the next module.
- k. Learners have access to programme facilitators and are encouraged to engage with their peers on the tasks and activities, within the modules. Orientations, webinars, support and focus groups are offered throughout the duration of the programme, as part of the e-learning experience.
- l. Reflections are included to encourage learners to learn from experience, think deeply about the decisions they make, and consider how and where they need to improve for success. They are also given multiple opportunities to consider the different ways in which they will apply and use the course content.
- m. The final assessments, leading to certification at NQF Level 5, is also done through the e-learning platform. (Refer to Higher Health's Policy on Assessment).
- n. Simple English is used as a rule, for ease of understanding and translation into other languages.
- o. The curriculum content is checked and updated regularly to keep up with the latest technologies, trends, and available information.
- p. Learner feedback is elicited regularly to inform changes on the e-learning platform.
- q. Learners complete a POPIA declaration as well as a declaration confirming that they completed the module content, activities, and the summative assessments. The latter declaration in q is an important release condition for access to the FISA assessment.
- r. The skills programme is of high quality and is offered in an affordable and cost-effective way. The end-to-end e-platform allows for economies of scale as the volume of learners increase.

6. Hybrid Learning

- a. Higher Health recognises that where a learner comes from influences his/her ability to cope with online learning. Students from more affluent areas have access to laptops and smart phones, and are more likely to adapt to e-learning environments, while students from less affluent areas, particularly in rural or peri-urban areas or townships are less likely to be digitally literate because of not having access to computers or smart phones, or not living in wifi-friendly zones.

- b. To ensure learner success, Higher Health holds weekend, holiday and afternoon camps within university or college computer labs. The purpose of these camps is to make learners comfortable with technology, and to provide access to devices and wifi if none are available.
- c. A facilitator and super-users are present to help learners who experience technical difficulties.
- d. Despite being in a classroom environment, the programme is still completed online.

7. Partnerships

- a. Higher Health has a tripartite partnership with the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations (QCTO) and the Health and Welfare (HW) SETA to develop and offer these e-learning skills programmes.
- b. Higher Health has partnered with a global technology company for its e-learning platform.
- c. Higher health is also reaching out to national and international donors to make the e-learning Skills Programmes available to as many learners as possible.
- d. Higher Health has considered the needs and desires of employers across industries, both nationally and globally, to understand the nature of soft skills required by the workforce. It is Higher Health's intention to formalise these relationships, so that employers recognise and give preference to learners with a NQF Level 5 certificate from Higher Health.
- e. Higher Health is also partnering with PSET institutions to offer its skills programmes to learners enrolled within these institutions.

